

Lesson 30: “The Prisoners Shall Go Free” (See L30 [Study Guide](#))

Purpose: To help class members rejoice in their opportunity to provide ordinances for the dead.

†1. Joseph Smith’s description of his oldest brother Alvin

Who are some men and women in your family who died before they could receive the gospel?

1. Through Joseph Smith, the Lord revealed the doctrine of priesthood ordinances for the dead.

Why do we perform ordinances for the dead?

†2. President Joseph Fielding Smith

†3. Historical Background

†4. Elder John A. Widtsoe

†5. Brigham Young

†6. Elder Rudger Clawson

2. The Lord commanded the Saints to build a temple in Nauvoo.

“On 19 January 1841, several months after the Saints had begun performing baptisms for the dead, the Lord commanded them to build a temple in Nauvoo (D&C 124:24-27).” (*Lesson Manual*)

What reasons did the Lord give for this commandment?

- D&C 124:25-27. (For “the Most High to dwell therein.”)
- D&C 124:28, 40-41. (To reveal additional priesthood ordinances.)
- D&C 124:29-30, 33. (To provide a place to perform baptisms for the dead.)
- D&C 124:55. (To have the Saints prove their faithfulness in keeping his commandments so He could bless them...)

The “Nauvoo Temple was the second temple built in this dispensation. One of the primary purposes of this temple was to provide a place for the Saints to perform ordinances such as baptisms and confirmations for the dead, the endowment, and temple marriage. These ordinances were not performed in the Kirtland Temple.” (*Lesson Manual*)

Read about the sacrifices Saints made to “build this temple.” See “[The Nauvoo Temple](#),” in *Our Heritage* (pages 58-50, first four paragraphs).

What impresses you about the sacrifices made by the early Saints in building the Nauvoo Temple?

For “a short time, the Lord permitted the Saints to continue performing baptisms for the dead in the Mississippi River (D&C 124:31–32; *History of the Church*, 4:xxxviii). But on 3 October 1841, the Prophet Joseph announced that “there shall be no more baptisms for the dead, until the ordinance can be attended to in the Lord’s House” (*History of the Church*, 4:426). On 8 November 1841, Brigham Young dedicated a temporary but carefully crafted wooden baptismal font in the basement of the unfinished temple (*History of the Church*, 4:446–47). Today all ordinances for the dead must be performed in temples.” (*Lesson Manual*)

What can we learn from the Saints’ determination to build a baptismal font before the temple was completed?

3. We should be enthusiastic and joyful in our efforts to perform baptisms for the dead.

Some “baptisms for the dead were done in the New Testament times following the Resurrection of Christ ([1 Corinthians 15:29](#)). However, the great work of providing saving ordinances for the dead is now the responsibility of Church members in this dispensation...

“... members of the Church who are 12 and older, including new converts, can be baptized for the dead. To be able to be baptized for the dead, a member must hold a current temple recommend. Male members must hold the priesthood.”

• D&C 128:17-18. “For we without [our dead] cannot be made perfect; neither can they without us be made perfect.”

President Gordon B. Hinckley: “That which goes on in the House of the Lord ... comes nearer to the spirit of sacrifice of the Lord than any other activity of which I know. Why? Because it is done by those who give freely of time and substance, without any expectation of thanks or reward, to do for others that which they cannot do for themselves” (“[A Century of Family History Service](#),” *Ensign*, Mar. 1995, 62).

†7. Elder John A. Widtsoe

†8. Ted L. Gibbons

†9. Elder Neal A. Maxwell

• D&C 2:1-3. How can performing baptisms for the dead help us turn our hearts to our ancestors?

• D&C 128:19, 22-24. “Now what do we hear in the gospel which we have received? A voice of gladness!”

Next Week: L31: “Sealed ... for Time and for All Eternity”; See L31 [Class Member Study Guide](#).

(You can download a free LDS Institute manual at: [Doctrine and Covenants Manual: Religion 324 and 325](#).) † •

†1. **Joseph Smith's description of his oldest brother Alvin:** "He was ... the noblest of my father's family. He was one of the noblest of the sons of men.... In him there was no guile.... He was one of the soberest of men, and when he died the angel of the Lord visited him in his last moments." (*History of the Church*, 5:126-27)

†2. **President Joseph Fielding Smith:** "In his Divine Comedy, Dante depicts the doctrine of damnation for unfortunate souls who die without a knowledge of Christ, as that doctrine was taught in the thirteenth century. According to the story, Dante is lost in the woods, where he is met by the Roman poet Virgil, who promises to show him the punishment of hell and purgatory, and later he is to have a view of paradise. He follows Virgil through hell and later into Limbo, which is the first circle of hell. Here are confined the souls of those who lived virtuous and honorable lives but who, because they were not baptized, merit punishment and are denied forever the blessings of salvation. As Dante looks upon these miserable souls in the upper stratum of hell and sees, as the story says, "many and great, both of children, and of women and men," he marvels.

"His guide asks: "Thou askest not what spirits are these thou seest?"

"Dante shows a desire to know, so the guide continues: "I wish thee to know, before thou goest farther, that they sinned not; and though they have merit, it suffices not: for they had not Baptism, which is the portal of the faith that thou believest; and seeing they were before Christianity, they worshipped not God aright; and of these am I myself. For such defects, and for no other fault, are we lost; and only in so far afflicted, that without hope we live in desire." (Philo M. Buck, Jr., ed., *An Anthology of World Literature* [New York: Macmillan Co., 1940], p. 446.)

"In answer to the earnest inquiry of his mortal guest, who desires to know if any thus punished ever had the privilege of coming forth from this sad condition of torment, the spirit-poet declares that the righteous who had known God from our first parents down to the time of Christ have been exalted. But of these unfortunates who never heard of Christ, he says, "Be thou assured, no spirit of human kind was ever saved." ("[Justice for the Dead](#)," *Ensign*, Mar. 1972, 2.)

†3. **Historical Background:** The "Lord began teaching Joseph Smith about work for the dead very early in the Prophet's ministry ([Joseph Smith—History 1:36-39](#); [D&C 2:1-3](#)). President Gordon B. Hinckley commented on this teaching:

"It is tremendously significant to me that ... this repetition of the wondrous words of Malachi concerning the work for the dead, was given to the boy Joseph four years before he

was allowed to take the plates from the hill. It was given before he received either the Aaronic or Melchizedek Priesthood, before he was baptized, and well before the Church was organized. It says much concerning the priority of this work in the plan of the Lord" ("[A Century of Family History Service](#)," *Ensign*, Mar. 1995, 61).

On "15 August 1840, the Prophet Joseph preached at the funeral of a Church member named Seymour Brunson. As part of his sermon, he read extensively from 1 Corinthians 15, which includes a reference to baptism for the dead (verse 1 Corinthians 15:29). Then he announced that the Saints could be baptized in behalf of their friends and relatives who had died without receiving the gospel. He declared that the plan of salvation was intended to save everyone who was willing to obey the requirements of the law of God. After this sermon, Church members began performing baptisms for the dead in the nearby Mississippi River." (See *Journal History of The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints*, 15 Aug. 1840.) (*Lesson Manual*)

†4. **Elder John A. Widtsoe:** "The beginning and end of the gospel is written in section two of the Doctrine and Covenants. It is the keystone of the wonder gospel arch; and if that center stone should weaken and fall out, the whole gospel structure would topple down in unorganized doctrinal blocks." (El Ray L. Christiansen, in *Conference Report*, [April 1960, 48](#))

†5. **Brigham Young:** "We trust in God. I reckon he will fight our battles and we will be baptized for and in behalf of the human family during the thousand years; and we will have hundreds of temples and thousands of men and women officiating therein for those who have fallen asleep, without having had the privilege of hearing and obeying the Gospel, that they may be brought forth and have a glorious resurrection, and enjoy the kingdom which God has prepared for them." (*Discourses of Brigham Young*, p401)

Recommended Reading:

1. President Joseph Fielding Smith, "[Justice for the Dead](#)," *Ensign*, Mar. 1972, 2.
2. Nancy Jensen, *LDS Gospel Doctrine Plus*, [Lesson #30](#).

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†6. **Elder Rudger Clawson:** "Some years ago, a brother approached me, and he said: 'Brother Clawson, I am sixty-seven years of age; I have been a strong and active man in my life, and have done a great deal of hard work, but now I am somewhat feeble; I cannot engage in manual labor as heretofore. How shall I spend my time?' I said to him, '[Go to the house of the Lord.](#)' 'Thank you,' he replied, 'I will take your counsel.' About eight years later, I met this brother again. He appeared to be very happy indeed; and there was an expression of joy in his countenance. 'Brother Clawson,' he said, 'during the past eight years I have been working for my ancestors, in the house of the Lord. After that conversation with you, I went east and I gathered up eight hundred names of my relatives; and during the past eight years I have personally officiated for three hundred of my ancestors, and I propose to continue on with the good work; I am happy for the Lord has blessed me.' He further said, 'I saw in a vision, upon one occasion, my father and mother, who were not members of the Church, who had not received the Gospel in life, and I discovered that they were living separate and apart in the spirit world, and when I asked them how it was that they were so, my father said: "This is an enforced separation, and you are the only individual that can bring us together; you can do this work; will you do it?"' (*Conference Report, October 1908, 74.*)

†7. **Elder John A. Widtsoe:** "In our preexistent state, in the day of the great council, we made a certain agreement with the Almighty. The Lord proposed a plan, conceived by him. We accepted it. Since the plan is intended for all men, we become parties to the salvation of every person under that plan. We agreed, right then and there, to be not only saviors for ourselves, but ... saviors for the whole human family. We went into a partnership with the Lord. The working out of the plan became then not merely the Father's work, and the Savior's work, but also our work. The least of us, the humblest, is in partnership with the Almighty in achieving the purpose of the eternal plan of salvation." ("The Worth of Souls," *Utah Genealogical and Historical Magazine*, Oct. 1934, 189)

†8. **Ted L. Gibbons:** "Any religion that can only deal with mankind in mortality automatically subjects most of the human family to whatever punishments await those who do not partake. Even the most aggressive religions have been unable to reach everybody on earth with their proselyting. And what about the uncounted billions that have lived while no one was proselyting for a particular faith.

"This is a reality with which every religion must deal. If the doctrines and or ordinances are necessary for salvation, then what of those who never so much as

hear of them? Are they to be eternally consigned to Limbo or Hell or worse?

"If God is truly just, some way must be found to teach the doctrines and perform the ordinances for those who leave mortality without an opportunity to hear and believe." (In his D&C Gospel Doctrine [Lesson #30.](#))

†9. **Elder Neal A. Maxwell:** "What we do on this earth is so vital, but it is actually a preparation for our labors in paradise in the spirit world. The scope in that spirit world is ten times as large as the demographics of this world. It is, though, a place of peace, a place of intense devotion. One sees in section 138 of the Doctrine and Covenants words that tell us about the character of God. Not only will the gospel go to those who have never heard of it, but also included are those who have been in transgression, in rebellion, and who have rejected the prophets." ("[The Holy Ghost: Glorifying Christ](#)," *Ensign*, July 2002.)

Recommended Pictures and Videos:

1. Pictures of the [Nauvoo Temple](#).
2. Video of [Elder Russell M. Nelson](#) (1:53).
3. Video of [Elder Richard G. Scott](#) (1:35).

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